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Hays County calls 2024 Road Bond election for November ballot

SAN MARCOS, Texas—On Tuesday, Aug. 13, the Hays County Commissioners Court approved 5-0 an order calling a bond election for Nov. 5. The 2024 Road Bond would add a total of \$0.02 per \$100 valuation to the county tax rate, which is recommended at \$0.35 per \$100 valuation.

“Our residents utilize roads daily and they continue to be one of the top issues of concern,” said Precinct 1 Commissioner Debbie Ingalsbe. “It is also important to have an open process to allow our residents to determine if this is a need they are willing to fund. I believe it is important to be conscientious about this bond’s financial impact on our families.”

Informational open houses will be held throughout the county in all precincts in order to better inform residents about the 2024 Road Bond prior to Election Day at times and locations to be announced at a future date.

The proposed measure totaling \$440 million focuses on projects already in the planning process to ensure continuity of projects and include shovel-ready projects. The selected projects will address substandard roadways to improve safety and increase capacity. As one of the fastest-growing counties, Hays County aims to increase commuter safety, mitigate congestion and create regional connectivity.

According to the Transportation Department, key benefits of the 2024 Road Bond Program include the following:

Improve Safety and Mobility: Improved roadways are essential for enhancing safety, reducing accident rates and ensuring better connectivity across the county. This bond has east-west connectors and the addition of shoulders to existing roadways, allowing for increased connectivity and safety.

Respond to Rapid Population Growth: Hays County is rapidly growing, with the population expected to grow 267% by 2045. This rapid growth necessitates an updated and expanded transportation infrastructure to meet the increasing demands.

Address Current Infrastructure: Many roads remain unchanged despite rapid population growth. An equitable bond budget per precinct ensures that all areas of the County are properly served.

Continue Long-Term Planning: 2016 Road Bond projects that have been developed will now be built with this 2024 program. More project development will occur in the 2024 program to set up projects to be shovel-ready for future state and federal funding opportunities.

Support Economic Development: Improved transportation networks can stimulate economic growth, attract businesses and enhance residents’ overall quality of life.

“Our county’s road infrastructure and public facilities play a critical role in fostering economic growth, ensuring the safety of our residents, and providing essential services to the community,” said Hays County Judge Ruben Bercera. “By calling for a countywide bond for road infrastructure, we can revitalize our roadways, attract

businesses, improve public safety and address the needs of our growing community. Investing in our county's future is an investment in every citizen's quality of life."

Precinct 1 projects totaling an estimated \$118.5 million include:

- Old Bastrop Highway/CR 266 (Centerpoint Road to Rattler Road)
- Cotton Gin Road/CR 129 (Bonanza Street to SH 21)
- FM 2001 East Interim (Graef Road to Southeast of SH 21)
- William Pettus Road/CR 238 (FM 110 to SH 21)
- High Road/CR 127 (East of Goforth Road to SH 21)
- Leah Avenue (CR 269 to Cottonwood Parkway)
- Dairy Road (Bunton Lane to Cotton Gin Road CR 129)
- Goforth Road (Bunton Lane to Bebee Road/High Road)
- Bunton Lane/CR 153/Heidenreich Lane/Grist Mill Road (Violet Lane to SH 21)
- RM 150 East (Precinct 1 Boundary to SH 21)
- Precinct 1 Discretionary Projects Preliminary Design

"The county will ask our voters to consider approving a road bond in November. As our county continues to grow, so does the need for a safer and improved transportation system. The east side has especially seen a deterioration of many major county roadways," said Ingalsbe. "Many of the projects in Precinct 1, such as Gristmill, Cotton Gin and High Road, are west-to-east connectors from I-35 to Highway 21, which are very much needed for safety, mobility and connectivity. Also, the Old Bastrop Highway in the San Marcos area, which leads to the San Marcos High School, is important for the safety and mobility of our students and families."

She added, "Thinking regionally is an important aspect and many of the projects throughout the county have that idea in mind. It's great working with our local municipal partners and our friends at TxDOT to leverage funds."

Precinct 2 projects totaling an estimated \$104 million include:

- Windy Hill Road Interim (Purple Martin Avenue to FM 2001)
- Windy Hill Road Roundabout (Windy Hill at Shadow Creek Boulevard)
- Windy Hill Road Ultimate (Purple Martine Avenue to FM 2001)
- FM 2001 Gap (FM 2001 West to Existing FM 2001)
- Hillside Terrace (I-35 to FM 2001)
- Goforth Road (CR 158 to RM 150)
- RM 150 East Preliminary Design (Lehman Road to Precinct 2 Boundary)
- Precinct 2 Discretionary Projects Preliminary Design

"There are numerous reasons for calling for the proposed road bond, but specifically we need to improve the safety and mobility of our road infrastructure to combat the rapid growth in our county and also to support the economic growth that is here now," said Precinct 2 Commissioner Dr. Michelle Cohen. "It is important to address the dated road infrastructure that exists in our rural communities and continue the proactive long-term planning of our roads."

Precinct 3 projects totaling an estimated \$109 million include:

- Centerpoint Road (I-35 to FM 2349/Hunter Road)
- Old Kyle Road (RM 12 to RM 3237)
- Yarrington Road (West of Arroyo Ranch to Old Stagecoach Road at RC 16)
- Yarrington Road (I-35 to Old Stagecoach Road)
- Dripping Springs Southwest Connection (U.S. 290 to Precinct 3 Boundary)
- Precinct 3 Discretionary Projects Preliminary Design

“In order to keep up with the rapid growth in Hays County, we will introduce to the voters the option to make continued investments needed in infrastructure,” said Precinct 3 Commissioner Lon Shell.

Precinct 4 projects totaling an estimated \$107.7 million include:

Darden Hill Road/CR 162 (East of Sawyer Ranch Road to RM 1826)
Darden Hill Road Extension (RM 150 West of Springwood Road to West of Sawyer Ranch Road)
RM 150 and RM 12 Intersection Improvements (RM 150 at RM 12)
Fitzhugh Road/CR 101 (RM 12 to Travis County Line)
Dripping Springs Southwest Connection (Precinct 4 Boundary to RM 12)
Sawyer Ranch Road Pedestrian Walkway (Meadow Creek Drive to Darden Hill Road)
Sawyer Ranch Road (U.S. 290 to Darden Hill Road)
SH 45 Southwest Extension (FM 1626 to I-35)
Old San Antonio Road Study (Main Street to Travis County Line)
Precinct 4 Discretionary Projects Preliminary Design

“Transportation and mobility and the ability of our residents to traverse the county safely is one of the highest priorities of the county,” said Precinct 4 Commissioner Walt Smith. “Given the massive growth in Hays County, and specifically in the Buda and Dripping Springs areas, the county must constantly identify needed improvements and changes, and the projects proposed in this bond have been well identified throughout to provide for the safe movement of our residents throughout the county.”

The 2024 Road Bond will now go before voters in the November election.

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